MAICON

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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

The Bottleneck of One: Why Your Marketing AI Leader Needs Builders

Date & time: Oct. 14, 3:05-3:40 PM EST
Track: Strategic AI



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Session Description

Dedicated Marketing AI leadership is catching on. Job postings for these roles are showing up where they did not exist two years ago, and at Veeam the model has spread to other business functions. But once the role exists, a new challenge emerges: that leader cannot do it alone.

Setting strategy, building the council, aligning stakeholders, making business cases, and proving ROI fills a calendar on its own, and none of it ships a workflow. Building the high-complexity, high-impact AI workflows that actually move the business is a different job. It takes focused, dedicated time, the kind a leader splitting attention across strategy, stakeholders, and outcomes simply does not have. Make one person do both, and you get a bottleneck of one, with your most valuable use cases queued behind each other.

This is the case for the team.

In this session, we'll explore:

- Why leading and building are distinct jobs that compete for the same calendar, and why one person cannot scale both
- Why dedicated AI builders belong embedded in marketing, not in a shared services or central IT team
- Why one builder did not double our capacity, and what did
- How to make the headcount case to leadership, even when there is no headcount to add

Whether your organization already has the leader or is still relying on a lone wolf, you'll leave knowing what comes next.

Key Quote

> *"So in the end, that bottleneck of one wasn't solved by two or even three. It was solved by 69 and counting."* **- Jessica Hreha**

Session Summary

Jessica Hreha, Director of Marketing AI Transformation at Veeam Software, returned to MAICON one year into her role to share “the receipts”: what worked, what didn’t, and what surprised her. She traced her path from launching a marketing AI council at VMware, to enterprise AI adoption advisory at Jasper, to stepping into the dedicated marketing AI transformation role at Veeam, a role she had advocated for across the industry.

Her starting premise was that if AI transformation is everyone’s job, it’s no one’s job, which is why Veeam created a dedicated role. But that role spans strategic alignment, governance, enablement, and outcomes, and her calendar filled with councils, governance groups, and global enablement sessions. Every meeting was leading, none of it was building, and that made her the “bottleneck of one.” Because her assessment survey showed training as the top barrier (named by 48% of respondents), she invested first in AI literacy, and 76% of the roughly 300-person global marketing organization now holds at least one AI certification.

Hreha was candid about what didn’t work. A third-party content tool pilot was outperformed or matched by Veeam’s internal Copilot and Azure-hosted ChatGPT systems. Bringing on a dedicated marketing AI architect, Johannes, and launching an Agent Accelerator Program produced strong wins, including a customer story agent that cut first drafts from two weeks to 30 minutes and an SDR agent that sourced a $425,000 opportunity. Still, subject matter expert review timelines and Copilot licensing constraints turned the bottleneck of one into a bottleneck of two, and planned “marcathons” never got off the ground.

The surprise came after Claude was rolled out company-wide, shifting her team’s focus toward enablement, alongside shared goals from the COO and CMO requiring an AI certification and at least one high-impact team-level workflow. While cleaning up a workflow tracker of roughly 90 initiatives, she found that 69 unique people were now leading pilots, nearly a quarter of the marketing organization, and hands-on labs had created 47 more builders. Examples ranged from Creative Studio’s self-service creative apps to a paid advertising specialist’s ad copy agent and an employee who became one of 18 global winners in a Microsoft agent competition.

Hreha concluded that she had been wrong about the fix: the expertise already existed, and enablement turned it into building. A builder’s job is to make building learnable, while her central team now focuses on complex cross-team workflows such as Harold, Atlas, and Event IQ. AI confidence rose from about 3.5 to nearly 4, and the top adoption barrier shifted from training to integration, time, and budget. Her next challenge is demonstrating business outcomes and ROI.

Key Takeaways

- **Leading and building are separate jobs.** Strategy, councils, governance, and enablement can fill a calendar on their own, so one person owning both leading and building becomes a bottleneck.

- **Let the data set priorities.** Hreha's assessment survey identified training as the top barrier, which led Veeam to invest first in an AI literacy roadmap that now has 76% of marketing certified.
- **Enablement multiplies builders.** Labs, peer sessions, and a shared pilot playbook grew Veeam from two builders to 69 pilot leads, something a dedicated team alone could not have matched.
- **Domain experts build within their own craft.** Teams like Creative Studio built tools that a central team never would have, which is why Hreha believes every function needs its own transformation team.
- **Point central builders at cross-team work.** With functions building for themselves, Hreha's builders focus on complex workflows that no single person owns, such as the Harold, Atlas, and Event IQ projects.
- **Make the headcount case creatively.** Look inside the organization for people already building, fund roles from the teams that benefit most, or invest in enablement and track what gets built as the business case.